

Leon Battista Alberti

The Early Renaissance architect, humanist, writer, priest, artist, linguist and philosopher Leon Battista Alberti (1404–72) is recognized as a founder of modern architectural theory, asserting that the ideal design is a balance of form, function and decoration. In 1447, he became architectural advisor to Pope Nicholas V. His design for the façade of the Palazzo Rucellai in Florence (1451, opposite) included pilaster orderings with Doric, Ionic and Corinthian columns, rusticated masonry and a heavy cornice. His façade for the church of Santa Maria Novella (1458–71), also in Florence, features a geometric pattern of multicoloured marble and an entrance based on elements of the Pantheon in Rome, with columns, niches, pilasters and volutes. From 1450 to 1468, Alberti reconstructed the Tempio Malatestiano in Rimini, turning it from a Gothic church into a Renaissance mausoleum, and basing the façade on an ancient Roman triumphal arch. His 1471 design for the basilica of Sant'Andrea, also with a colossal triumphal arch, served as an important model for many later Renaissance churches.

